The Gospel of Wealth

Andrew Carnegie · North American Review · June 1889 · excerpts

Source: The Andrew Carnegie Collection, carnegie.org; original publication, North American Review v. 148.

Steel magnate Andrew Carnegie was, by 1889, one of the richest men in the world. In this essay he argued that the rise of vast inequality was both inevitable and beneficial — but that the rich had a moral duty to administer their surplus wealth for the public good during their lifetime. He distinguished 'wise' philanthropy (libraries, universities, parks) from 'indiscriminate charity' (giving directly to the poor).

Connect: Gilded Age industrialists used the same 'natural laws' argument that antebellum slaveholders (Class 19) used to defend slavery as a 'positive good.' What's the pattern?

Key Passages

On inequality as 'natural'

> The conditions of human life have not only been changed, but revolutionized, within the past few hundred years. … We accept and welcome … great inequality of environment; the concentration of business … in the hands of a few; and the law of competition between these, as being not only beneficial, but essential to the future progress of the race.

The duty of the rich

> This, then, is held to be the duty of the man of wealth: First, to set an example of modest, unostentatious living, shunning display or extravagance; … and after doing so to consider all surplus revenues which come to him simply as trust funds, which he is called upon to administer … in the manner which, in his judgment, is best calculated to produce the most beneficial results for the community.

Famous line

> The man who dies thus rich dies disgraced.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — describe change over time: Describe ONE way Gilded Age wealth concentration differed from earlier American wealth distribution.

2. What does Carnegie consider 'good' giving vs. 'bad' giving? Whose perspective is missing?

3. How might a Populist farmer in 1889 have responded to this essay?